



AFTER WORK: Students playing football at IIM, Ahmedabad

The first IIT was set up in 1950 in Kharagpur at the Hiji Detention camp site based on the recommendation of the Sarkar Committee. Four other campuses were subsequently established in Bombay (1958), Madras (1959), Kanpur (1960), Delhi (1961), with the sixth campus in Guwahati in 1995 and the seventh in Roorkee in 2001. They were conceptualised as centres of excellence where professionals contributed to industrial development. The Indian Institutes of Management, on the other hand, entered the scene almost a decade after the establishment of IITs, to provide management education to professionalise the running of vital sectors like agriculture, health and energy. IIM, Ahmedabad, and Kolkata were set up in 1961, Bangalore in 1973, Lucknow in 1984, Kozhikode in 1996 and Indore in 1998. The seventh IIM in Shillong will be up and running by 2008.

The biggest achievement of IITs has been the establishment of a clear brand name. "It's like going to the market and buying an A-list product. You know that it will deliver and a basic level of quality is guaranteed," says Kushal Sen, dean, placements and training at IIT, Delhi. Devi Singh, director, IIM, Lucknow, adds, "There's a fanaticism about quality and a certain sanctity of process that has always been maintained. Nobody has compromised on standards."

There has also been an uncanny ability to sense the tide. Sen believes that IITs set up departments in potentially promising disciplines even before the government and private schools responded to the market demand in that area. A cen-

tre for nanoelectronics coming up at IIT, Mumbai, and the department of energy studies at IIT, Delhi, are a case in point. Over the decades, IITs and IIMs have seen a silent transition—from being teaching schools they have created original cutting-edge knowledge of their own. Seventy per cent of India's Ph.Ds in engineering are from IITs. IIMs, on the other hand, were mandated to produce new knowledge. Rama Bijapurkar, management consultant and IIM-A alumnus, says, "IIM-A responded to every discontinuity—political, academic or economic even when the education policy remained static." Originally set up to make interventions in the field of management, IIMs have evolved many hybrid models through a range of programmes in agriculture, public policy, fast track executive learning and social entrepreneurship.

The hallowed portals of knowledge have certainly come a long way in their journey of excellence. Anant Sundaram who teaches at the Tuck Business School at Dartmouth in the US and Indian School of Business, Hyderabad, and is an IIM, Bangalore, alumnus feels there is still more to be achieved. "For a country like ours, which has a long tradition in management education, we should have been the world leaders by now. The fact is that most of the original research work is still being done by Indians working abroad."

Amit Patra, dean, alumni affairs and international relations at IIT, Kharagpur, is more upbeat. "Two decades ago, we would classify some of our dreams as unrealisable. We would not even dare to compare ourselves with the best in the world. We put limits on our abilities." This is no longer true. ■

JAWAHARLAL NEHRU, at IIT Kharagpur, 1956

"Here stands this monument representing India's urges, India's future in the making."